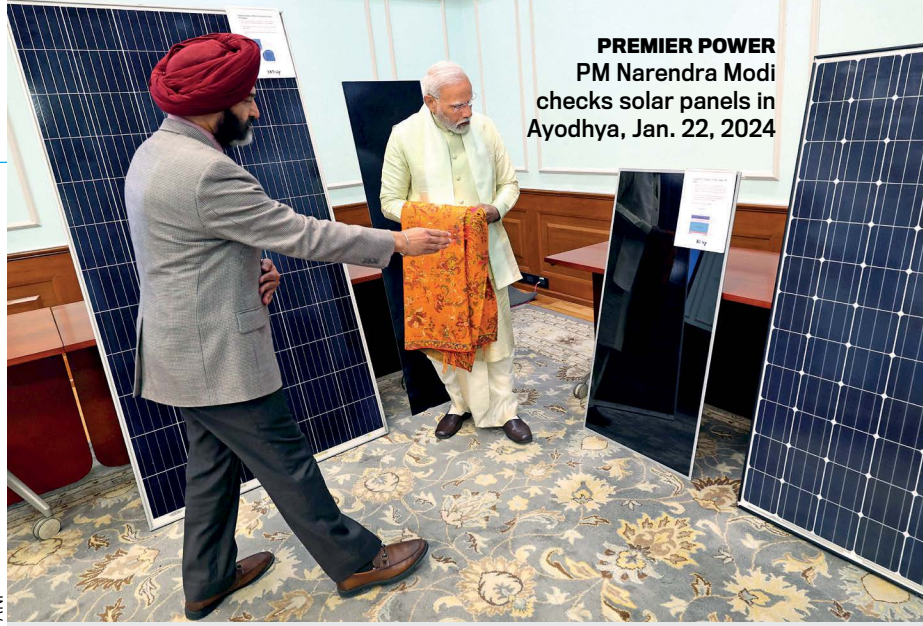


PREMIER POWER
PM Narendra Modi checks solar panels in Ayodhya, Jan. 22, 2024

ANI

idential installations by the end of the year, but the need is to quadruple that figure by 2030, says Saptak Ghosh, a senior policy specialist at the non-profit Centre for Study of Science, Technology and Policy (CSTEP).

Addressing teething troubles

MNRE has been trying to iron out the creases—the fear of discoms, or electricity distribution companies, losing consumers, the complicated process of getting subsidy and poor awareness—in the old RTS policy. Firstly, to simplify the process for consumers, a national portal was set up and launched on January 9. Consumers can now register on https://pmsuryaghar.gov.in/ following which they are directed to the portals of individual discoms to complete the power purchase agreement. A 150-day window is available thereafter to get the installation done via empanelled vendors. Once the work completion details are uploaded and the local discom synchronises the RTS with the grid, the subsidy is released within 30 days.

Secondly, the subsidy amount was increased. Earlier, the central financial assistance offered was Rs 18,000 per kW for 1-3 kW and Rs 9,000 per kW for installations ranging between 4-10 kW systems. Now, under the Muft Bijli Yojana, the subsidy has been enhanced to Rs 30,000 per kW for 1-2 kW systems. Assuming a benchmark cost of Rs 50,000 for 1 kW, this means that the consumer has to pay only the balance of Rs 20,000. A further subsidy of Rs 18,000 can be availed for an additional kW—hence, for setting up a 3 kW system, the total subsidy available is Rs 78,000. Besides, consumers can avail finance from banks for installations.

Going by the RTS calculator on the national portal, if a household paying Rs 2,000 toward monthly electricity charges in Delhi instals a 1 kW rooftop system, it can expect a payback period of under six years—a 24 per cent return on investment. The lack of trained manpower is also being addressed.

EVERY HOUSE AN ENERGY PRODUCER

That's the ultimate goal of the PM-Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana. The benefits: savings for consumers, extra power for discoms and a boost to India's clean energy commitment. These are its salient features

- **The target** of the Muft Bijli scheme is to instal rooftop solar systems in **10 million** households
- **New national** portal **https://pmsuryaghar.gov.in/** launched in January to simplify process of registration/installation
- **Consumers can** now choose RTS vendors from empanelled list after comparing prices
- **The total** subsidy outlay is **Rs 75,021 crore**
- **Subsidy** to be released within **30 days of uploading** commissioning report
- **Enhanced subsidy** for **1-2 kW** systems—60 per cent of benchmark cost for systems up to 2 kW (approx. **Rs 30,000 per kW** for 1-2 kW systems), and a further 40 per cent **(Rs 18,000)** on an additional kW. Total subsidy capped at **Rs 78,000** for systems larger than 3 kW
- **Bank finance** available for consumers

Rooftop solar awareness

Awareness about RTS has been low and residents perceive rooftop solar systems to be costly investments, according to a November 2023 report by the think tank Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW). In terms of awareness, Gujarat, which leads the country with 2.5 GW of installed RTS capacity, has been an early mover. The western state had a headstart in RTS when Modi, as Gujarat chief minister, first announced a policy in 2009.

"Every stakeholder was actively engaged. National Banks would give loans for rooftop photovoltaic with KYC details, and not demand income proof and other documents," says Kunj Shah, chairman of the renewable energy committee at trade body Assocham's Gujarat chapter. In February 2024, the state's energy minister Kanubhai Desai pointed out that 82 per cent of the country's solar rooftops were in Gujarat—about 545,000 RTS units out of an estimated total of 693,000. The government buys the excess electricity generated at Rs 2.25 per unit, which has